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MY THOUGHTS SHARED

October 8, 2013

0 notes &

Demystifying decisions makers' needs in sudden onset disasters

Making decisions in a disaster can be very sensitive business. We always want to make the decision that will save the most lives, eliminate the most suffering or maximize aid efficiency. However, in a disaster, we often have to make rapid decisions with the limited information that we have on hand. This situation creates a type of "focusing illusion" where we take action based on what we see and know versus what we could know. And, as I outlined in a recent post about [measuring impact](#), the decision may seem prudent at the time but can look irresponsibly negligent in hindsight. In decision making, looking back does not necessarily prepare us well for the future. We need to augment historical reviews by openly articulating what decisions we commonly need to make in emergencies, what information is needed for each decision, and what factors can influence these decisions.



A couple years ago, a [small group of interested humanitarians](#) from the Volunteer & Technical Communities, academia, [UN-OCHA](#) and [ACAPS](#) discussed the topic of humanitarian decision making and realized that we (as a larger community) needed to start mapping out the decisions made in emergencies and the related information requirements. We needed to help open up the humanitarian community in a way that external entities could help us. As we enter a [Age of Context](#) (mobile, social media, big data, sensors and location), as defined by Robert Scoble and Shel Israel, we are going to need as much help as possible to make sure that we can distill the increasing amounts of data into the "little data" needed to respond effectively. In order to kick-start the process, [UN-OCHA](#) and [ACAPS](#) organized a workshop focused on Field-Based Decision Makers' Information Needs in sudden onset disasters. Given the [breadth of decision makers](#), we needed to focus our scope to ensure a concrete deliverable.

We held the workshop in late 2012 with the objective to create an initial framework for decision making and an initial scope of the information requirements in the first phases of a sudden onset disaster. We pulled in several very seasoned disaster responders and spent two days asking them questions and brainstorming with them. We focused on the early phases of an emergency and on decisions with scopes ranging from inter-agency to inter-cluster to cluster-specific to organization-specific. The [workshop report](#), which we are releasing today, aims to allow others to prioritize their efforts toward important information and to organize their information in a

My story



I am a disaster responder and information management officer for UN-OCHA. I have a passion for simple and sometimes even seemingly childish innovative new concepts. I want people to collaborate with me to find the best solutions, new ideas, problems with my logic, and new bits that make my ideas work. I want to put my pieces on the table and start working. I do not believe that I have brilliant ideas, but rather I want to discover them.

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manner intuitive and useful to humanitarian decision-makers. It provides a framework and set of information required by field-based decision-makers, a list of categories and types of decisions made by decision-makers, and a large set of brainstormed decisions from workshop participants.



Although the report is full of rich content, it is Table 12 (page 38) that comprehensively captures the “things” workshop participants wanted to know in a coherent and general framework. I found this table to perhaps be the most powerful piece of the report as it provides the general framework with a set of questions that we, as a community, could use to knowledgeably build out processes and solutions to support specific decisions/questions and eventually bring appropriate data into a large, overall emergency dashboard. Of course, others will find different pieces of the report more relevant. Table 8 outlines different Decision Dimensions: Time-frame, Scope, Locus/Authority, Criticality, Frequency/Duration, Information Gap, Function. Pivoting these dimensions onto each other creates different possible decision frameworks such as Figure 4 which combines Scope, Criticality and Information Gap. Essentially, we can now combine these different dimensions to better understand possible ways and influences on how people make decisions.

I believe that this report is a great start and will help us move forward in a structured way. Although information in each emergency may need to be framed slightly differently, we can start with the report's framework and build out a predictable base to start with each time. Combining predictable information, in a structured and digestible format, with experienced responders will facilitate better, faster decisions thereby saving more lives, eliminating more suffering and improving aid efficiency.

Andrej

Are you subscribed by email?

FYI: As a side note, I am happy to see organizations like Medecins Sans Frontieres (MSF), who launched MSF Speaking Out, leading the way by opening up details around major decisions that they have made in the past so that others can more easily study and support the humanitarian community.

Filed under decision makers, data, open

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Jakob Rogstadius

10 years ago

Thank you, this report will be very helpful for the technical community.

Just to clarify the scope - you recently posted a decision maker taxonomy map. I note that the participants of the workshop that this report is based on come exclusively from international organizations. How well would you estimate that this report covers the information needs of decision makes from the remaining groups in the taxonomy?

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Andrej Verity Mod

→ Jakob Rogstadius

10 years ago

Hi Jakob,

Although I suspect that there will be significant overlap with some of the branches in the taxonomy (especially in the type of information required) there will be other branches where it is quite different (e.g. affected individual vs the Head-of-Office of a international organization).

During the workshop, we discussed the need to investigate a range of different decision-makers groups: affected community, global-level (i.e. not in-country) organizations, etc. We may find that the "information" required is similar, but needs to be categorized, processed and presented in different ways. And that the "depth" of the information needed is quite different for different groups over the course of an emergency.

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Jakob Rogstadius

→ Andrej Verity

10 years ago

That agrees pretty well with what I've seen from other sources, thanks.

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https://blog.veritythink.com/post/63454573734/demystifying-decisions-makers-needs-in-sudden-onset

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